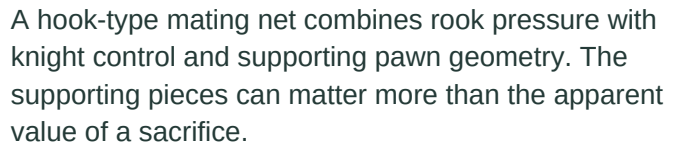


Hook mating nets

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Identify the final checking line and then trace which friendly pieces protect the attacker and control the king's exits.

Previous move: 26...Kd8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

27. Rf8+ Kc7 28. Rc8#

27.Rf8+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **27...Kc7**.

28.Rc8# Mate: rook on c8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on c7. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on c8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

Recount the king's legal replies after each move. A changed pawn placement can destroy an otherwise familiar mating pattern.